

## 2+ ADD-ON

# GitHub 101: Saving, Sharing, and Undoing Your Work

### READY-MADE MATERIALS

Use these when nobody has their own. Everything here is public or was written for this course.

#### Note to send tonight

Tomorrow we'll spend 45 minutes on GitHub. Before we start, please make a free account at `github.com` with your personal email, verify the email, and turn on two-factor authentication when it asks. No installs needed; we'll work in the browser. If you already have an account, check that you can sign in.

#### Demo repository

`github.com/jblakeslee89/llm-revealed-preferences`. Public. 74 commits, each with a one-line reason and a `Co-Authored-By` line naming the model. A `.gitignore` that keeps copyrighted PDFs ( `literature/` ) and the key file ( `.env` ) off GitHub, and a `.env.example` showing where a key goes without containing one.

#### Practice repository

Name: `ai-group-notes`. Private. Tick "Add a README file." First file: `prompts.md`, holding one before/after prompt pair from Session 1. Session 3's scripts go in the same repository in two weeks.

#### Starter README

```
# ai-group-notes

What this is: my notes and working files from the RAND AI Facilitation
Group, fall 2026.
What's here:
- prompts.md: before/after prompt pairs (Session 1)
- scripts/: analysis scripts written with the model (Session 3)
- skills/: my skill docs (Session 5)
What's not here: any RAND project data, keys, or copyrighted readings.
```

#### Starter .gitignore for research work

```
# keys and settings
.env
# data and readings stay local
data/raw/
literature/
*.pdf
# clutter
.DS_Store
__pycache__/_
~$*
```

Good and bad commit messages

Bad: update , fixes , asdf . Good: Drop 2019 rows counted twice in the merge , Add Session 1 prompt pair on the GAO summary . One line, starts with a verb, says what changed and, if it isn't obvious, why.

Git-tutor prompt

I'm new to Git and GitHub. Here is exactly what I did and the error I got: [paste]. Explain what happened in plain language, then give me the smallest safe fix. Do not suggest force-push, reset --hard, or deleting the repository.

Something to break on purpose

In the practice repository, edit the same line of the README on two branches, then try to merge both. GitHub shows a merge conflict and a web editor to resolve it. Better to meet one here than in a thesis chapter.